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Romance *in the Air*

Actress **SHAHANA GOSWAMI** on her Indo-Australian romance drama *Four Years Later*

In a career spanning two decades, Shahana Goswami has been a part of only two stories that had romance at the centre of them. The first was *Ru-Ba-Ru* (2008), and the second is *Four Years Later*, an eight-part Indo-Australian series created by Mithila Gupta. Co-starring Akshay Ajit Singh, the show revolves around a newly-wed couple forced to live apart as the husband moves to Sydney while the wife continues to live in India. "The portrayal of their lives felt very real. The kinds of issues in their relationship were nuanced and mature. It isn't just typical male-bashing or gender normative issues between couples," says Goswami. Shot in Mumbai and Jaipur before moving to Sydney, the show uses both English and Hindi. "It was so refreshing to have Indian characters in the lead who spoke in their natural accents."

Ever since her first film *Yun Hota Toh Kya Hota* (2006), the 39-year-old has been a part of international projects like Deepa Mehta's film adaptation of Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children* (2012) and Mira Nair's series adaptation of Vikram Seth's *A Suitable Boy*. The actor was last seen in British-Indian documentary filmmaker Sandhya Suri's searing *Santosh* (2024), about a young widow who joins the police and investigates the murder of a Dalit girl. The film, which premiered at the Cannes Film Festival to acclaim, was the UK's official entry to the Oscar's International Feature Film category, and earned a BAFTA nomination for Best Debut Feature. *Santosh* has been denied certification for release in India after the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) objected to its portrayal of police brutality, caste discrimination and misogyny.



The CBFC objected to **portrayals of police brutality**, misogyny and caste prejudice in the searing *Santosh*

Goswami has been part of several international indie films that haven't released in India, but the disappointment for *Santosh* is more profound. "This is a story that is so rooted in India that I think it'll resonate with large sections of the audience. That's why I feel so bad about this decision. I'm still hopeful though. I believe that the amount of debates that have happened because of this film and others that have been blocked in some way or the other, are creating a larger dialogue for change."

For now, the actor is looking forward to the release of her next film—*Mahasangam*, co-starring Abhishek Banerjee and Neeraj Kabi. Directed by Bharat Bala, it is set against the backdrop of the Maha Kumbh Mela in Prayagraj. "It's a sweet family film which we shot during the Maha Kumbh, which was a unique experience. A.R. Rahman has done the music and it was great moment for me to be lip-syncing to his music." Towards the end of July, Goswami will start shooting for an untitled film that deals with conservation and environment through the lens of mythology. She's also hoping to make a foray into production with a travel documentary 'with a difference'. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay